SELLING EXPERIENCES

As competition increases, luxury wildlife properties are differentiating themselves through experiences that extend beyond safari vehicles.

At Outpost 12—a nine-cottage lodge in Kanha—sundowners, says stargazing, Star Bed experience, nature walks, and chef-led cooking classes have become popular. "Many of our guests have already experienced wildlife destinations in Africa and other parts of the world, and are now looking for similar, immersive experiences in India," says Durgesh Singh, Founder Director, Sinali Experiences, a conservation travel and wildlife community that runs Outpost 12.

At Sariska Lodge, wildlife holidays include horseback experiences, heritage walks, visits to local artisans, wellness treatments, and private dining. Founder Anand Shekhawat says the 11-suite property recorded an average daily rate of approximately ₹30,500 and an average stay of 2.5 nights during its first year.

Experiences are also helping resorts attract families and younger travellers. The Oberoi Vindhyavilas offers naturalist-led village walks, birdwatching, tiger storytelling and dedicated children's nature programmes.

At Corbett Hideaway, General Manager Ajay Kareer says guests increasingly want to understand the landscape and local communities rather than merely collect photographs of wildlife. Experiences range from Kumaoni village walks and riverside trails to mountain drives and private breakfasts.

This interest in nature-led hospitality is visible even outside dedicated safari resorts. At The Tamara Coorg, nearly 70% of guests participate in at least one guided plantation or forest trail during their stay. According to Samir MC, CEO, Tamara Leisure Experiences, participation in nature-led activities has increased by approximately 25% over the past two years.



"Luxury and conservation are not contradictory. Low-density, high-value tourism can actually be far more appropriate for a wildlife destination"

KAPIL CHOPRA
FOUNDER AND CEO,
THE POSTCARD HOTELS

The opportunities are varied and the examples are plentiful. For example, Taj Corbett Resort & Spa conducts Ragas by the River, an annual music festival, on the banks of the Kosi River. The luxury residential festival, now in its third edition, brings together music, curated culinary experiences, and luxury hospitality against the backdrop of the Corbett landscape. It generally takes place in March, and a three nights-four days package, including stay and performances, is priced around ₹240,000. Not far away, The Riverview Retreat recently hosted the inaugural Corbett Literature Festival, bringing writers, conservationists, photographers and storytellers together for three days of conversations about nature, wildlife and the Himalayas. Priced ₹45,000-55,000 for a three-night all-inclusive package, the festival offered guests everything from literary discussions to nature walks, Kumaoni cuisine, and folk performances.

For hotel companies, these experiences have an additional commercial advantage. They create reasons to visit even when parks are closed or safari access is restricted.

Chadha says ITC Hotels is developing demand through food, wellness, nature and local culture rather than relying on a single activity or season. "The answer lies in ensuring that the resort experience is not entirely dependent on the safari," he says.

Andicot cautions that premium room rates and additional spending on curated experiences do not necessarily make wildlife resorts more profitable than city hotels. Seasonality, accessibility, and higher operating costs remain important considerations.

Chadha says although wildlife properties have less corporate and events business than urban hotels, limited competitive supply and premium pricing during the October-to-May/June safari season can help offset that disadvantage. "The